

I was the bottleneck in my own business (this book fixed it)

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Executive Summary

Drawing on *Who Not How* by Dan Sullivan, Tim Luong explains how founders trap themselves by always asking "how" instead of "who," and shares five lessons — including why cutting his team in half increased revenue.

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The Core Shift: "How" vs. "Who" 0:00

- Tim opens with a striking result: cutting his team from **60 to 30 people** led to making *more* money — and this book explained why
- In the early days of Stock Navigators, his calendar was packed with low-value tasks
 - Scheduling, texting, admin, emails — all piling up daily
 - By the time sales calls came (the actual revenue-generating activity), he was mentally exhausted
- He acknowledges that doing everything yourself is necessary at the very start
 - "In the early days, when you start out and you don't have money, you don't have experience, you do have to do everything yourself. It's called survival."
 - But at some point, survival mode *becomes* the problem
- His fix: hired an assistant to offload the low-value tasks
 - The assistant's hourly cost was significantly less than what Tim could generate per hour on a sales call
 - Result: got his time back *and* his mental bandwidth and energy back
- The central thesis of *Who Not How* (by Dan Sullivan & Benjamin Hardy):
 - Most founders default to asking: **"How do I solve this?"**
 - The question they *should* be asking: **"Who do I need to hire or ask to solve this for me?"**

- Tim realized he had been applying this instinctively — but instinct doesn't switch on automatically for most founders
 - The "how habit" doesn't turn off the moment revenue starts coming in
 - Even after you can afford to hire, you'll still find yourself solving everything — not because you have to, but because that was the identity you built at the start

"What got you from zero to 30K or 50K a month will be the same thing that prevents you from getting to 300K a month."

- The how trap is deeper than just delegation
 - Delegation is the *mechanism*; the how trap is the *mindset underneath*
 - The default belief: "I am the correct answer to every problem in my business"
 - Delegation only happens once you successfully break that belief
- The real work: catching yourself *in the moment* when you default to "how" instead of "who"

😞 **Procrastination as a Signal, Not a Flaw 1:36**

- Most founders treat procrastination as a character flaw; the book reframes it as the subconscious sending a message
- The specific scenario: the task that has been on your to-do list for weeks
 - You feel guilty about it
 - You keep telling yourself "one day I'll get to this"
 - Yet you can't bring yourself to do it
- Tim's old response: push harder, be more disciplined, wake up earlier
- The reframe: **procrastination means you are not the right person for that task**
 - Reasons could be: lack of skill, lack of bandwidth, or simply no genuine interest
 - Tim admits he ground through work that "was never mine to do" for years
 - Accepting he wasn't the right person felt like weakness — this is why founders get stuck
- The guilt loop that traps founders:
 - Feel bad about not doing the thing → avoid it more → feel worse → task never gets done
- The correct response is NOT "push through it"
 - It's finding the person best suited to tackle it
 - Key insight: the task draining you might be the very thing that *energizes* someone else
- This isn't a procrastination fix — it's the **first sign that who you are right now needs to change**
- Practical reframe question:
 - Don't ask: "Why can't I get this done?"
 - Ask: **"Why am I the one who has to do this in the first place?"**
 - The answer to that question is your next "who"



Cutting the Team in Half — and Making More Money 2:27

- With 60 employees, Tim thought he had fully applied who-not-how
 - He was removing himself from nearly every "how" by hiring for each problem
 - But he found himself solving *people problems* instead of problems that moved the business forward
- Decision: cut the team in half — removing underperformers, people causing issues, and drama-creators
 - At the time, many people told him this was insane
 - Result: **revenue went up**
- Lesson: you can apply who-not-how and still get it wrong
 - The difference between finding *a who* and finding the *right who* is enormous
- What wrong hires actually cost the business:
 - They create drag on your top performers
 - They slow down decisions
 - They redirect your focus from growth into babysitting and managing people who shouldn't need managing
 - The cost isn't just their salary — it's every hour your A-players spend working *around* them instead of driving the business forward
- Two-part test to identify a bad hire quickly:
 - **Part 1:** Their work quality is consistently off standard
 - **Part 2:** Your best, most trusted people don't want to work with them and keep bringing up their name
 - If both are true simultaneously, the decision is already made — you're just delaying it
- Every day you delay has a price
 - Most founders wait 6 months for a decision they could make today
 - Common reason for delay: not wanting to go through the hiring process again ("where will I find someone to replace them?") — this is just another version of the how trap
- On identifying the right hire:
 - You will know within the **first 30–60 days** if a hire is right
 - Pay attention to what you actually see — including red flags, not just the positives
 - "You've got to kiss a lot of frogs before you find the right one" — making bad hires is part of the process, not a sign you're doing it wrong
 - Every bad hire teaches a lesson to adjust in the next hire



The Delegation Ladder: Sequence Matters 3:50

- Most founders think of delegation as offloading work; founders who actually scale treat it as a **deliberate climb**
- Tim's personal sequence:
 - Step 1: Delegated admin and customer support — the lowest hourly-rate tasks he was doing personally

- This freed him to focus entirely on sales calls, the single highest-leverage activity at that stage
- Step 2: Once he got good enough at sales to document and teach a process, he found someone *better* than him at it and trained them
- Step 3: Every role he removed himself from allowed him to level up one rung in the business
- Common mistakes founders make with delegation:
 - Trying to delegate everything at once
 - Delegating the wrong things first
 - Result: nothing changes, or things get worse
- The model is a **ladder** — the *sequence* of steps is just as important as the steps themselves
 - Remove yourself from the bottom rungs first → frees up energy to perform better at the top
 - What you perform better at → document it → teach and train someone better than you → pass it off
 - Each exit from a task is an entry to running a better version of the company
- What the ladder is really doing: sequencing the *evolution* of your business
 - You're not just removing tasks — you're deliberately forcing yourself to operate at a higher level each time
 - Once lower-leverage work is off your plate, you have no choice but to show up differently
- **Practical tool: the 90-day calendar audit**
 - Every 90 days, review your actual calendar (not where you *planned* to spend time — where time *actually* went)
 - Every meeting, every recurring task, everything you touched in the last 90 days
 - For each item, ask: "Is this still the highest use of my time in the next 90 days? Or is this a how that belongs to a who?"
 - Tim now runs this audit for his entire leadership team, not just himself
 - Goal: build an organization where every leader is climbing the same ladder
 - Done consistently, this becomes the *way you operate*, not an occasional exercise

The Emotional Work of Letting Go 5:20

- The reason some companies reach 100 people while others get stuck at 10 has nothing to do with:
 - Market timing
 - Intelligence
 - Capital
- Tim has watched founders with better products and bigger budgets hit permanent ceilings, while others with none of those advantages scaled past them
- **The difference: whether the founder could stop being the answer** — not occasionally, not when convenient, but for good
- Knowing the framework and actually *living* it are two completely different things

- A quote from the book that stuck with Tim: > "The definition of hell is you will meet on the last day of Earth the who you could have become."
 - This isn't just a business insight — it's a question about your whole life
- The emotional work is harder than the logistical work
 - You will hire wrong
 - You will keep people too long
 - You will hold on to things you're good at — because handing them off will feel like shrinking
- What separates founders who build something lasting:
 - Not that they avoided mistakes
 - They stopped letting those mistakes be the reason to jump back to doing everything themselves
- Once the shift becomes real — not just understood intellectually, but *actually lived* — the ceiling disappears
- Closing challenge to the viewer: "The question is just how long you're going to keep being the reason it's still there, or are you the reason why it ends up breaking."